

Historic Facts *and* Fancies

History and Landmarks Section
of California Federated
Women's Clubs



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The sailors and volunteers had not the least idea of forming a hollow square to resist cavalry, and Mervin ordered them to close up when the lancers charged toward them. The sailors and marines obeyed orders and so formed a compact mass of two hundred and fifty men, crowded together. Two of the crew dismounted, the others holding the horses, one maneuvering the pole up and down, right and left, until the gunner got the range, when he fired, and, at the same time, the lancers charged, but wheeled about as soon as the gun was discharged; the gunners jumped on their horses and were off at full gallop until they got far enough ahead to reload, when the same maneuvers were repeated. In all, four shots were fired in this manner, the swarthy cannoneer depressing his piece every time, so as to strike the ground, and the ball, ricochetting, spent its force in the solid mass, killing or wounding two or three every time. The volunteers would obey orders to close up, but kept in scattered order, trusting to their rifles to repel the cavalry, running and firing on the gunners with the hope of disabling them, and hitting neither horses nor riders. The running fight was kept up for about three miles, to the slough boundary of the ranch. Then the gun stuck fast and the Americans came near capturing it. The Californians plied their spurs and crouched to their horses' manes, while a shower of bullets whistled by them, pulled their gun out and loaded it with their last ball to await another attack; but Mervin had got enough. The day was very hot and it was still ten miles to town, with that gun firing at them with deadly aim every half mile; he ordered a retreat to the ranch.

"They carried their killed and wounded back to the house, piled their ghastly load on one of the Dominguez carts, made an old Californian, who was in charge of the house, mount his horse and hitch his riata to the tongue to steer the craft while the sailors hauled it by hide ropes down to San Pedro, when they re-embarked."

Manuel Dominguez married Maria Eugracia Cota, daughter of Don Guillermo Cota, commissioner under the Mexican Government in 1827. Ten children were born to this union; eight daughters and two sons. The names of the surviving daughters are Mrs. Victoria Carson, Mrs. John T. Francis, Mrs. Charles Guyer, Mrs. Gregoria Del Almo, Mrs. Dolores Watson, and Miss Dominguez.

Lost Woman of San Nicholas Island

(Some extracts from an article in *Overland Monthly*, May, 1896, by L. G. Yates, of Santa Barbara.)



SAN NICHOLAS ISLAND, one of the group of the Santa Barbara Islands, is about nine miles in length and four in width; water is plentiful; was formerly densely populated, but now is a treeless waste—the result of fire and the pasturage of sheep.

We learn by tradition that the Alaska Indians, who were placed upon this island to trade with the natives, killed off the male inhabitants and took possession. In 1835 the padres sent a vessel to remove the women and children. This was accomplished, with the exception of one woman, who jumped into the surf and swam ashore to hunt for her child, who had accidentally been left behind.

The next we hear of the lone woman was in 1850, after a lapse of fifteen years, when Captain Nidever, of Santa Barbara, visited the islands and

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discovered traces of recent habitation; but it was not until 1853 that the female Robinson Crusoe was found and removed to the mainland, where from the sudden and complete change of manner of living, she soon died. She had outlived her people and found no one able to converse with her in her almost forgotten language. It is supposed she was the last of her race; her clothing, made from skins, and needles of bone, were deposited in the Vatican, at Rome.

But the incidents connected with her stay upon and removal from the island will soon be forgotten, although the refuse heaps of its former inhabitants will remain as evidence of a lost people.

Who can realize the utter and wretched loneliness of the poor creature, who spent eighteen years among the deserted homes of her ancestors, where the ground was whitened by their bleaching bones?

Old Streets of Santa Barbara

Woman's Club, Carpinteria, Cal.

OURNAL OF ELECTRICITY, January, 1903, speaks of quaint Santa Barbara, renowned for its history, its missions, and its curiously named streets. For instance, a century or more ago one particular road out of the settlement became so muddy each winter that it became famous as a quagmire. It is a street now called "Salsipuedes," meaning, "Get out if you can!" Then there is "Canon Perdido street," where a cannon was mysteriously lost during General Fremont's time. And another, a lane in which a prosperous ranchero was robbed of \$500 three generations ago, is now called "Quinientos street," meaning "500 street."

From the State Capital

Kingsley Art Club.

R. JOSEPH SIMS, who came to California in 1849 and is now residing ten miles from Sacramento, related the following story:

He drove to Sacramento one morning and as he was walking along Front street he noticed several coops of chickens. As eggs were only \$6.00 per dozen and had quite a mineral taste, he asked the price of a dozen hens. He was told he could have eleven hens with an "escort" for \$50.00. He paid the price and took the chickens home. His partners in business thought he had been very extravagant so would not enter into the new enterprise; consequently when eggs began to appear they were found only at the plate of the owner of the eleven hens and "escort," unless paid for at the regular market price. His partners in business soon became tired of this arrangement and bought an interest in the chickens, which paid well until eggs went down to \$1.00 per dozen, when the business was abandoned.